

Loops, Dramatic Elements of Game Design

Today

-Game Loop

-Dramatic Elements

-What a game ***really*** is

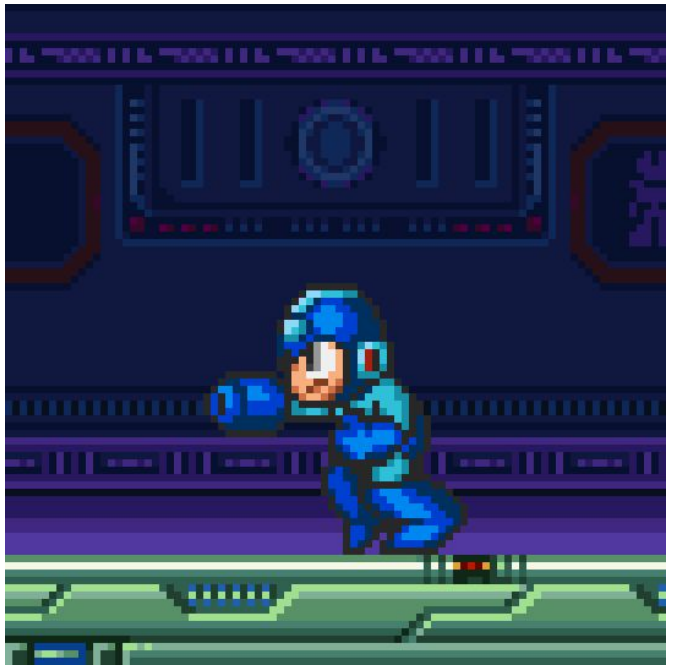
Game Loops

Game Loops

- Video games are programmed with common procedures, functions, actions.
- Any game has a handful of things you do over and over again, which make up its primary experience



- Halo: **Run, Jump, Shoot**

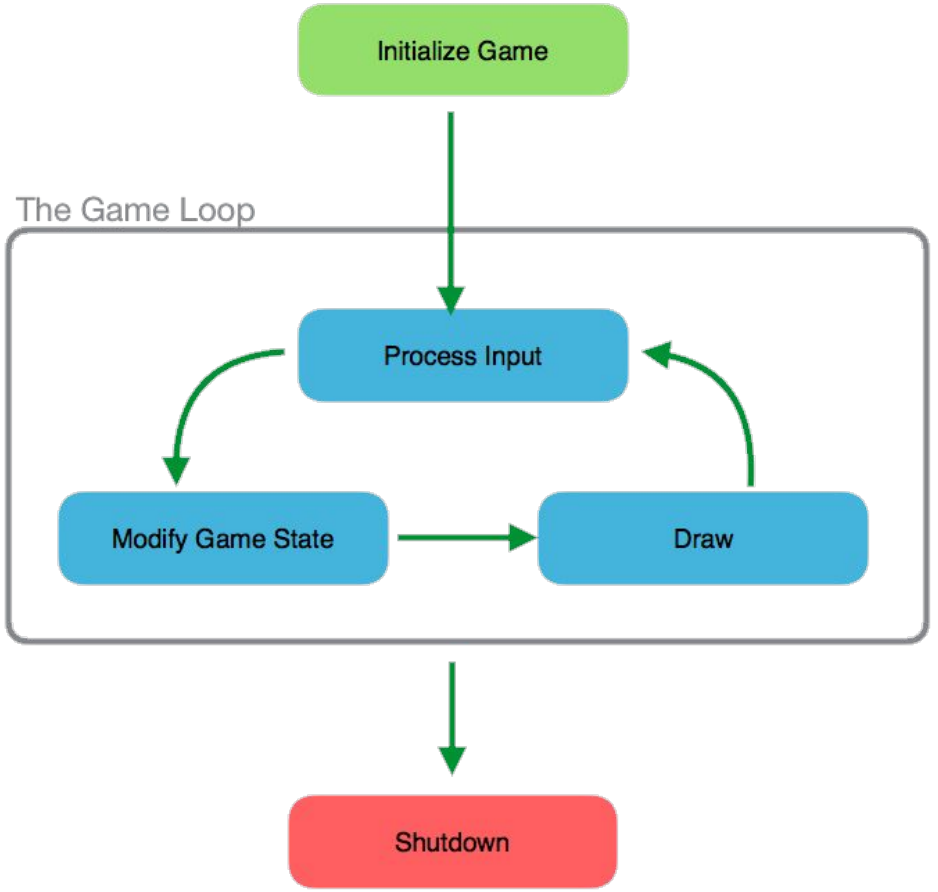


- Megaman: **Run, Jump, Shoot**

Game Loops

The Game Design “Game Loop” is NOT the same as the Game Programming “Game Loop”





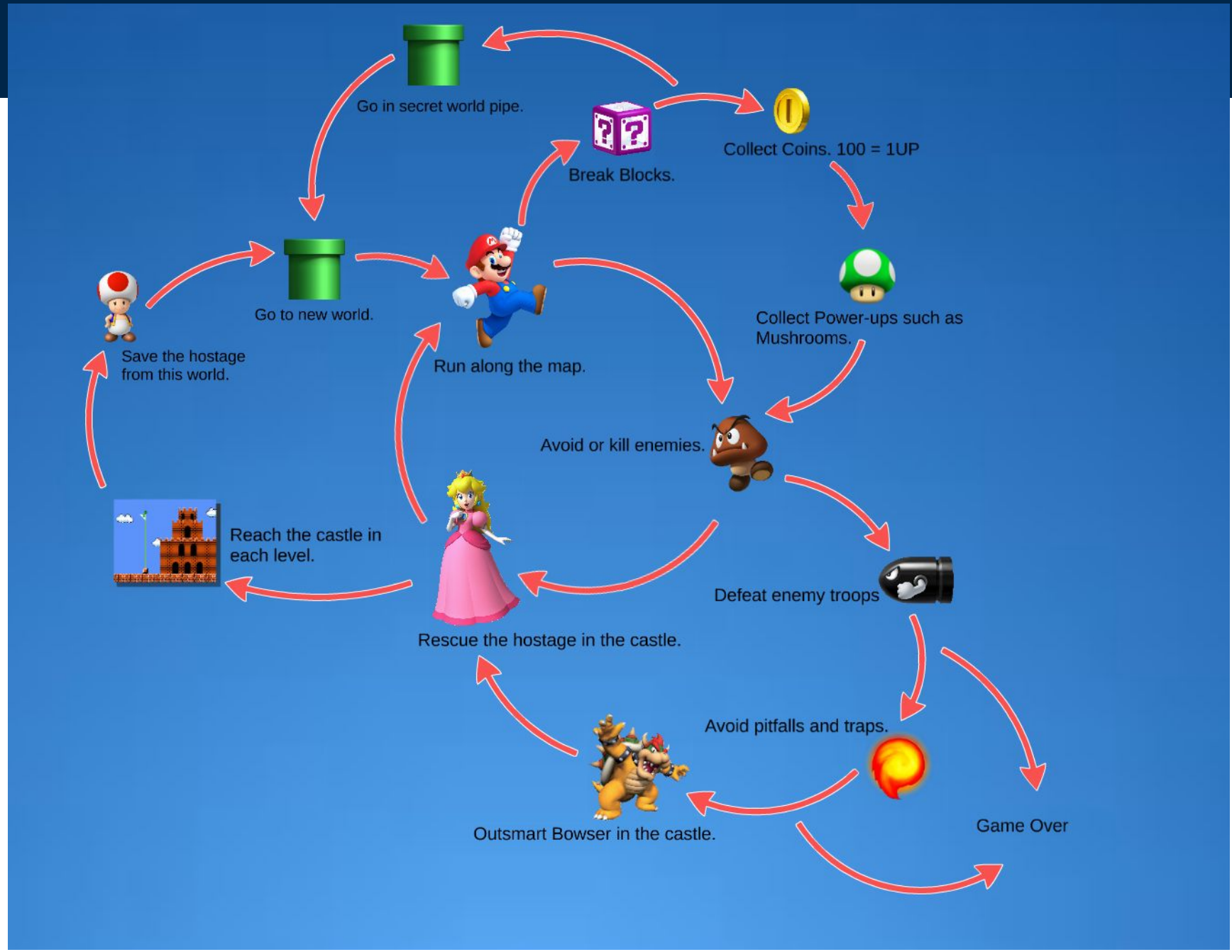
Game Loops

- Video games are onions. They have **layers.**
- Multiple loops can exist on **different time scales or different dimension**s



Game Loops

- You have a **CORE GAME loop**, supported by other secondary loops e.g. resource gathering/upgrades, level progression/story progression



Game Loops Examples

DARK SOULS

Fight encounters, Complete puzzles, Beat Area Boss, Unlock new area,

Gather materials, upgrade gear

Explore, fight, light new bonfire, rest/level up

Pick target, kill, reset

Run, Strike, Roll





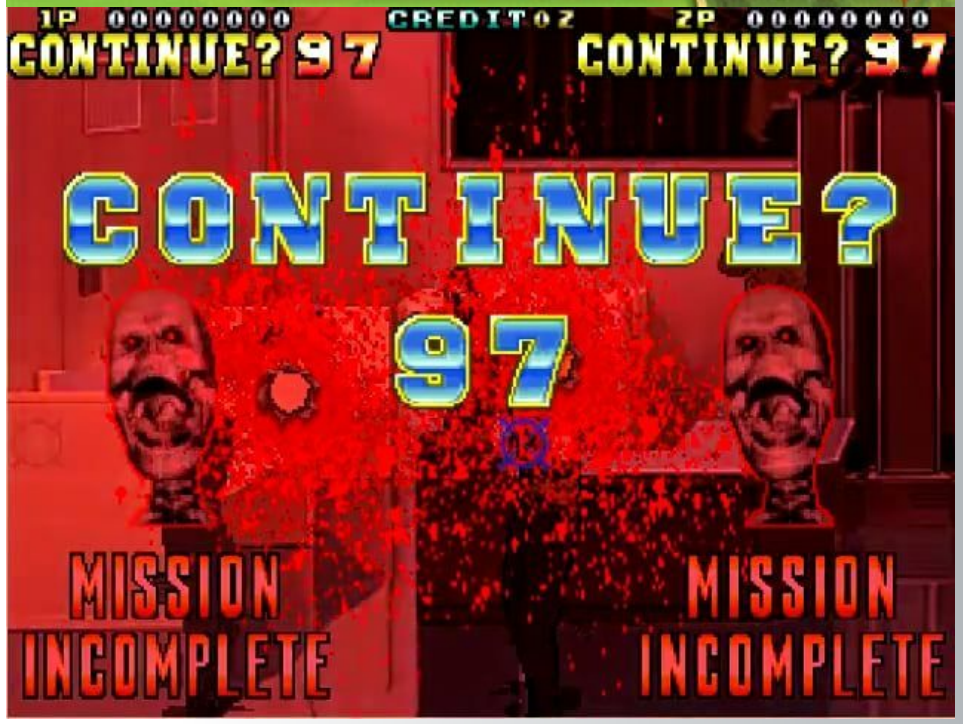


Significance of the Core Game Loop

Designing games with Core Game Loops in mind allows you to:

- Focus resources on polishing gameplay which players experience for the entire game
- Monetize at points which players will care about





Designing with Core Game Loop

Overwatch

- **Focus:** significant time spent on simple **run-jump-shoot** loop for every character
- **Monetization:** sells cosmetics– something you see in core gameplay
- **Designers choose to show you to the team** so you can see your cosmetics, and others you might want to buy





Activity

Question

1. What actions do you **do most often** in your game?
2. Identify all **Game Loops and the Core Game Loop**.
3. Are these actions the **most fun parts** of the game?

Disclaimer: Culture Items

1. I am but one human
2. I will present some culture items
3. Not everyone will recognize every cultural reference
4. I will try my best not to stick too much to each one, to keep you from feeling alienated
5. I will try my best to present neutrality and offer you ways to suggest your own culture items, but I will still have inherent systemic biases inside and outside my awareness

Also I'll try not to give spoilers for recent games

Dramatic Elements of Game Design

Dramatic Elements

- What makes games interesting?

There are some common threads…

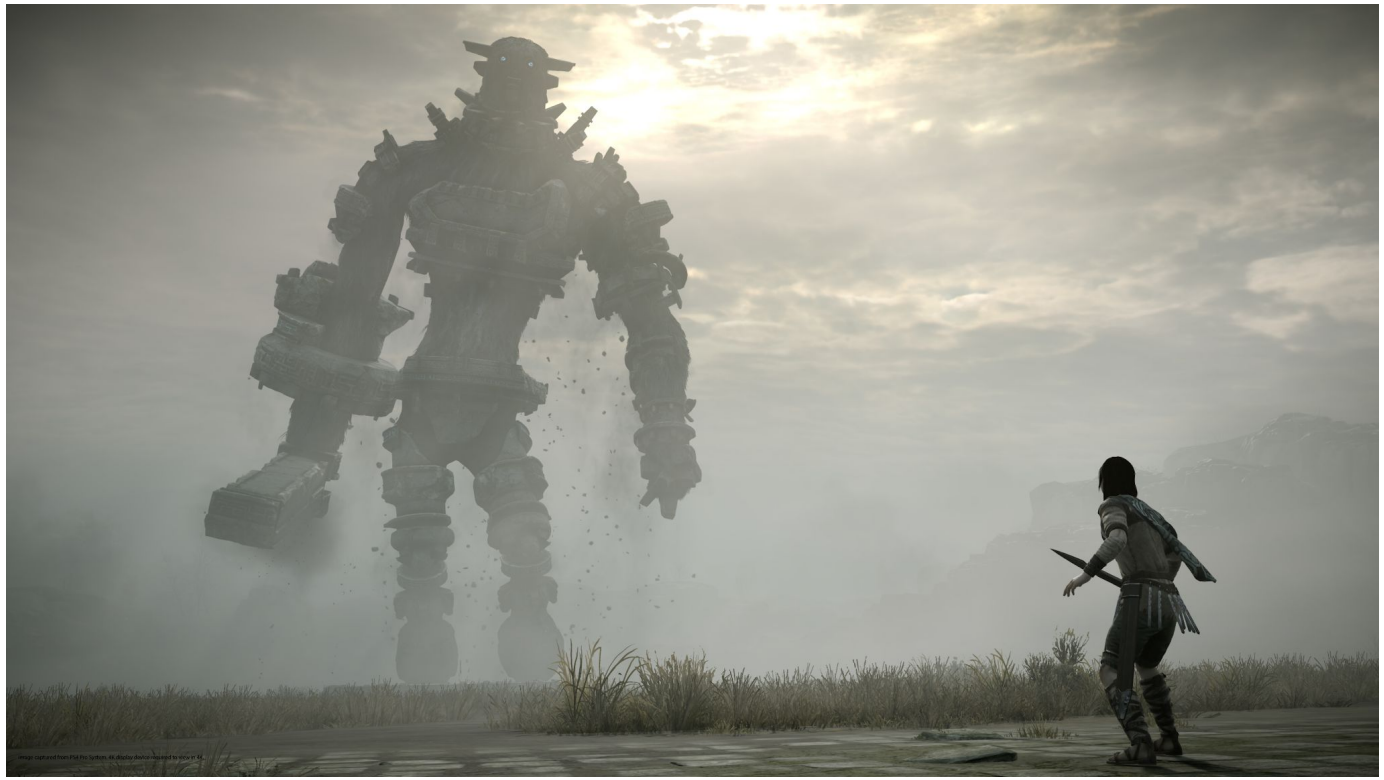
1. Challenge
2. Play
3. Premise
4. Character
5. Story

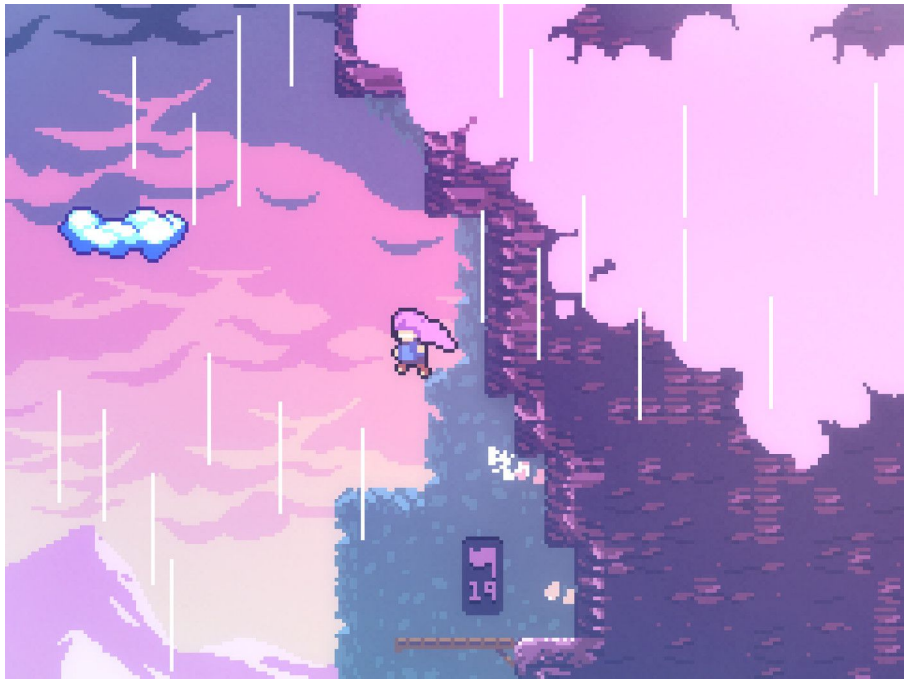
- They are called the "**dramatic elements of game design**" because each engage the player on an emotional level by creating dramatic context for **formal elements.**

- Unlike the formal elements, they are not integral parts of a game's existence.

Challenge

- What is difficult in the game? Is it combat? Is it story decisions?
- How does this affect the player's **personal narrative**
- **Will you create a Video Game WAR STORY?**






Destroy the PCA SP autonomous craft BALTEUS
SPEED
383
284
185m
ACS ANOMALY
AP
06517
EXPANSION
0
REPAIR
1
SCAN
BOOST ON
LB
RELOAD
72
RB
RELOAD
92
LA
—
RA
RELOAD
67
211

Challenge

- How will you make challenges which help create emotional impact instead of frustration?
  - Clear goals, clear path to victory, clear paths to failure, clear feedback
  - Art supporting feeling of challenge. Match the challenge with appropriate narrative context! Or otherwise show that you (the devs) are in on it with the player e.g. https://www.unfair-mario.com/ https://store.steampowered.com/app/240720/Getting_Over_It_with_Bennett_Foddy/



Activity

Discussion

Should Dark Souls (and other difficult games)

have Difficulty Settings?



Play

Hard to define.

Is a baby with a rattle “playing”? What are the rules? Objectives? Conflicts?

- One definition is: “free movement within a more rigid structure” (Salen and Zimmerman).
- Even though play is abstract, it points out the opportunity for players to use **imagination**, social skills and other free-form interaction types

Play

- Play can be serious. Typical examples are a Grand Master match in chess but with the rise of eSports, even games like League of Legends, Dota2, Starcraft 2, etc can be played at a very serious level.

- Tigers play for sport… and practice their hunting skills
- Being able to design games for different appeals of fun while also providing some freedom for imagination is key to engaging players

Activity

Discussion

How does Play in

The Sims create **Narrative**?

What features support this?



Premise

- A premise gives context to the formal elements of your game
  - The premise in **Monopoly** is that players are each landlords buying, selling and developing valuable pieces of real estate.
- Premises include **setting**
- Premise allows players to **contextualize** their choices. Make sure it supports gameplay.
  - The premise of Pokemon was made for… catching and training Pokemon.

Character

- Traditionally characters are **agents** through which dramatic stories are told and they function similarly in games.
- But uniquely in games, characters are vessels for our participation and entry point for our experience with the game.
- A strong character can often compensate for derivative story. Many **first-person shooters** don't offer anything new in terms of gameplay elements but make up for it with a fun character (Master Chief, Duke Nukem, Serious Sam, etc).

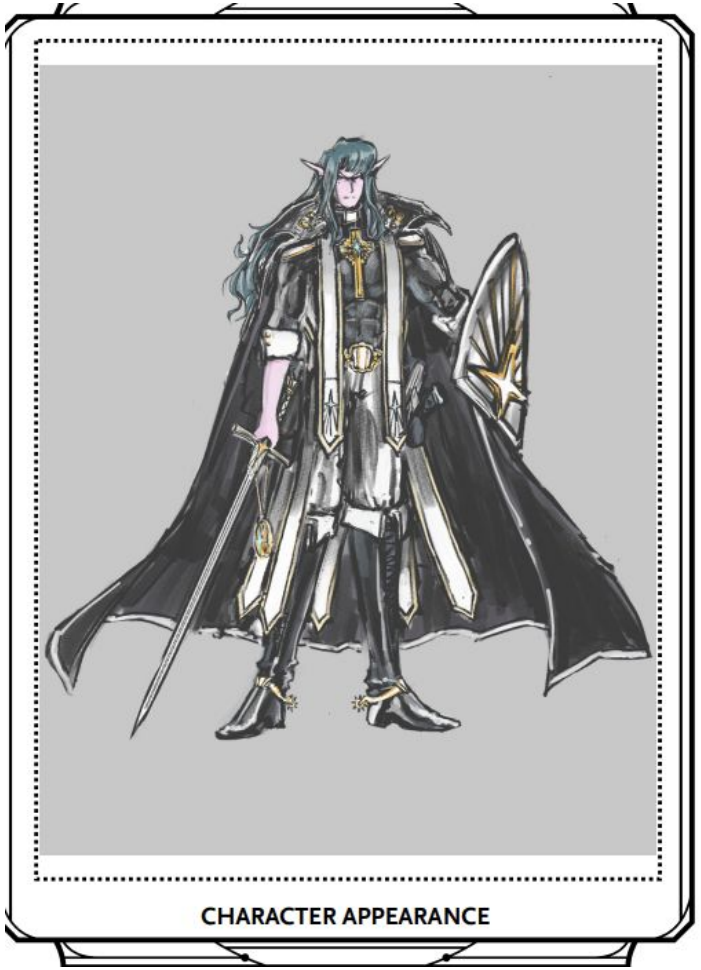
Quick Characters

DnD breaks it down pretty well to start

- Personality Traits - what are they like day-to-day
- Alignment - what is their moral compass, how do they handle Principles
- Ideal - what do they value? What are their principles?
- Bond - what are they connected to
- Flaw - what are they bad with

Just add:

- Goal → What do they want?
- Things blocking that goal → Why can't they get what they want?



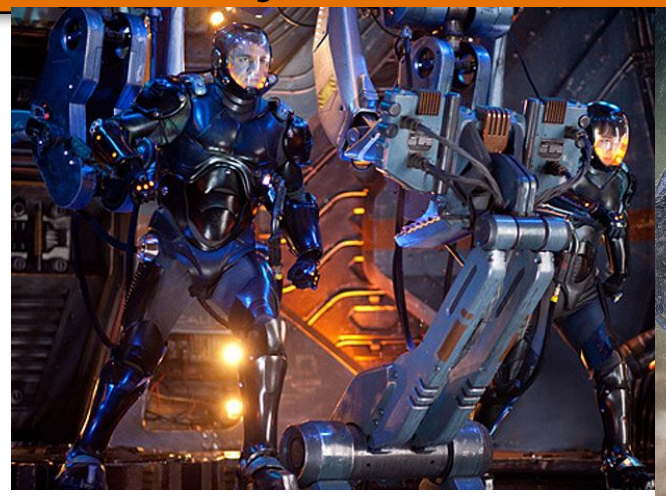
Story

- Games may engage players emotionally by using story within their formal elements or surrounding their formal elements
- Difference between a premise and story is that a premise is a state, whereas a story unfolds over time.

Activity

Discussion

In Pacific Rim (2013), there are 2 Pilots to each Jaeger (Giant Kaiju-fighting robot)





Why is this part of the premises?

What is it about?

Activity

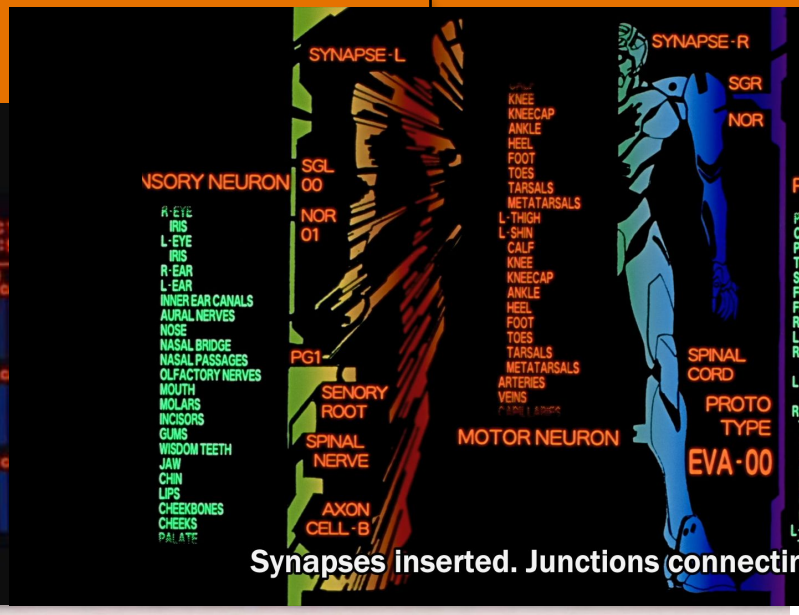
Discussion

In Neon Genesis Evangelion (1995), Pilots have “sync” ratios with their EVA (Giant Kaiju-fighting robots), and feel the physical sensations of their EVA’s own nerve endings

Why is this part of the premises?

What is it about?





There is an adolescent girl inside this robot who can feel its every sensation



Activity

Discussion: Featured Games

What are examples of **The Game Loops**

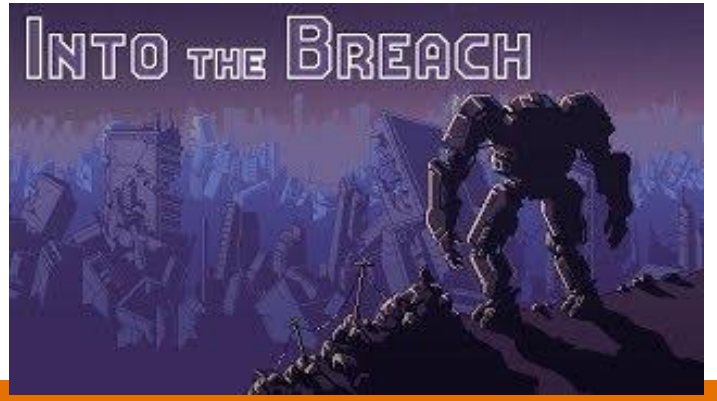
In these games?

What are their primary **Dramatic Elements?**

Papers, Please



Into The Breach



Theme: What is it about?

Activity

Discussion

What are some games with powerful Themes? What elements enforced these themes?

Themes - Death Stranding







From premise…

1. The Afterlife is confirmed to be real
2. The Internet works through the **Beach**… the space between the Life and Afterlife
3. At some point, connection to **Beach** is severed.
   a. Souls can no longer pass on through the **Beach**, return to Bodies
   b. Souls returned to Bodies create spooky umbilical-cord **BT (Beached Thing)** ghosts that cause **huge antimatter annihilation** events when they make contact with a living human
4. Distrust/distancing from other **Bodies/Souls** leads to a “Quiet Apocalypse”
5. Future UPS Delivery staff now hold the world together
6. The entire economy runs on facebook **likes**
7. Some people get so addicted to **likes** they let **likes** control their lives
8. Sam the delivery man is the son of the U.S. president, literally allergic to human touch, and his Soul keeps returning to his body when he dies, but without spooky ghost stuff.

Themes: Body & Soul. Birth, Death, Afterlife, Internet, Social media addiction, Isolation, Social distancing, Bonds & Attachment, Stranding. **Not being able to move on.**

Characters reflect the themes but with their own personal flaws/bonds that relate to other things. Miss an identity or parts of their identity, have a singular focus, are stuck in the past, can’t get close to people, etc.

Themes - Silent Hill & Space Silent Hill

What are some themes in…

- Silent Hill
- Dead Space

Zombies, yes. Definitely. What else?

Haunted by ex?





Subtext

- Subtext is “between the lines”
- Whether you intend it or not, your game will have **subtexts**.
- IF paid attention to, you can create deep narrative and theme.
- IF ignored, it will be at best mediocre. Possibly offensive, probably just boring.

What do your game mechanics say?

What are the themes and subtext of Monopoly?

- Overtly: gain land, get rich. Rich get richer
- Subtext: that initial boost has nothing to do with skill. It is up to **random chance**

Where do I get Themes and Subtext?

1. Born from gameplay mechanics
2. From life experiences
3. Recombined from other media/literature

Understanding the value of your game

What makes a game?

Most people do not understand what really makes up the identity of a game.

It’s something invisible.

What makes Halo *Halo*? It’s not shooting. Call of Duty has shooting.
What makes Call of Duty *Call of Duty*?

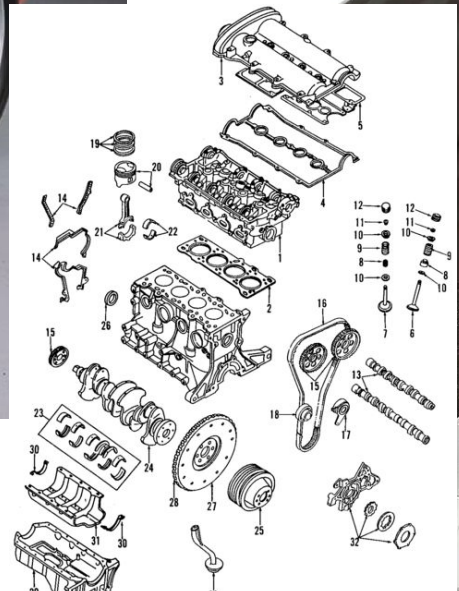
What makes League of Legends?

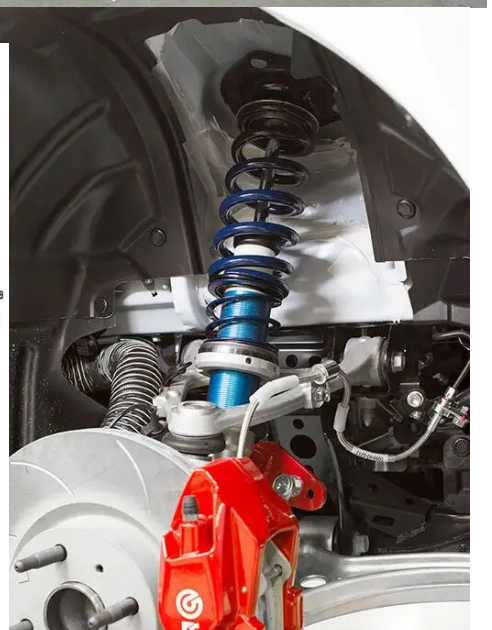
What makes a game?

This is NOT a car.





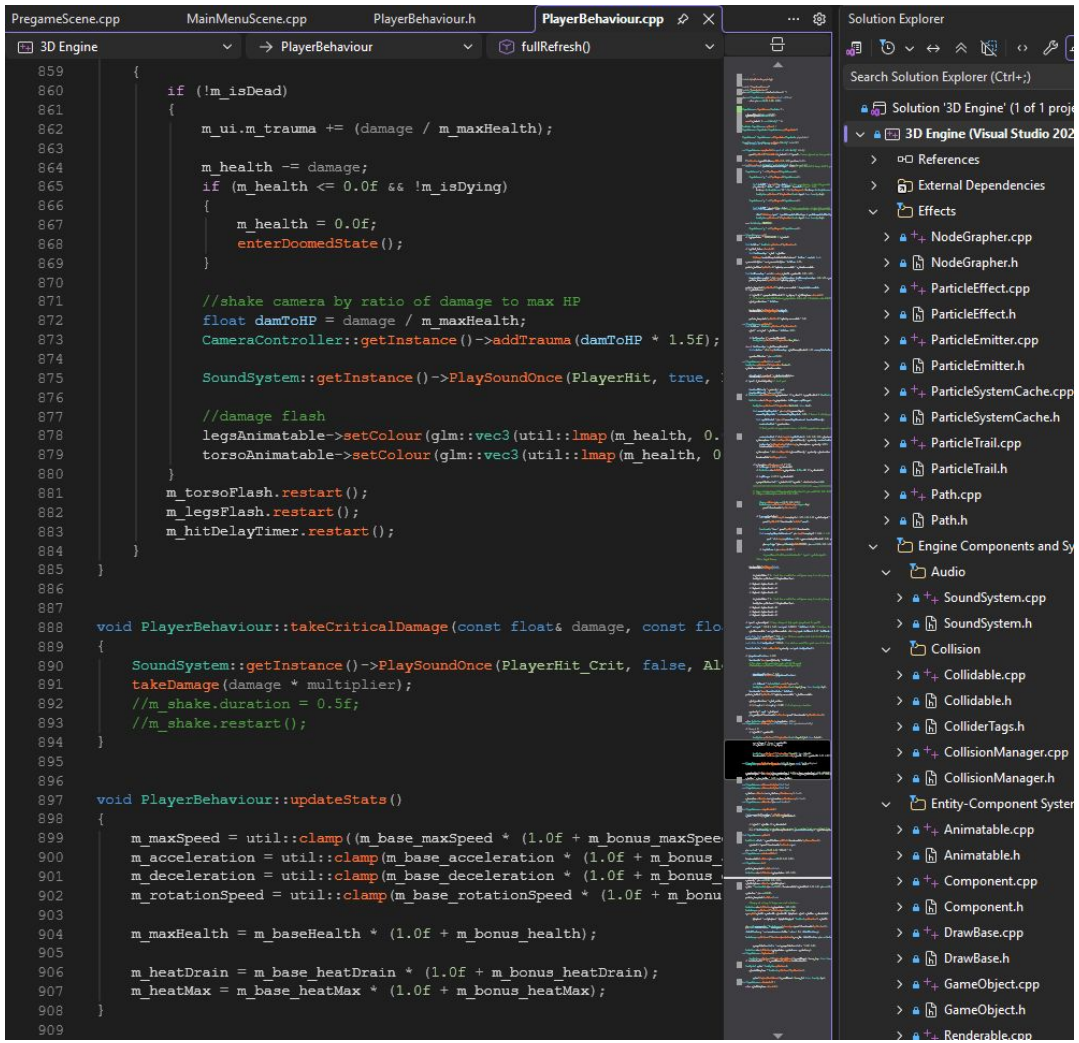


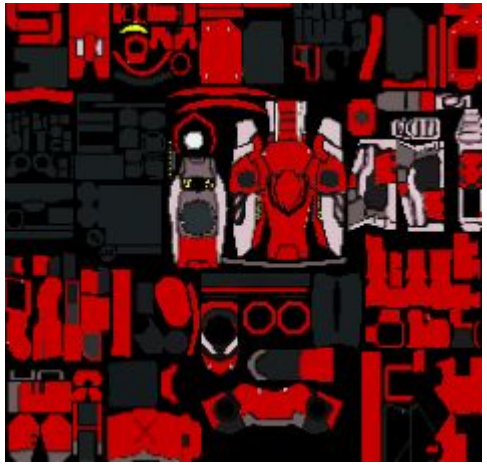


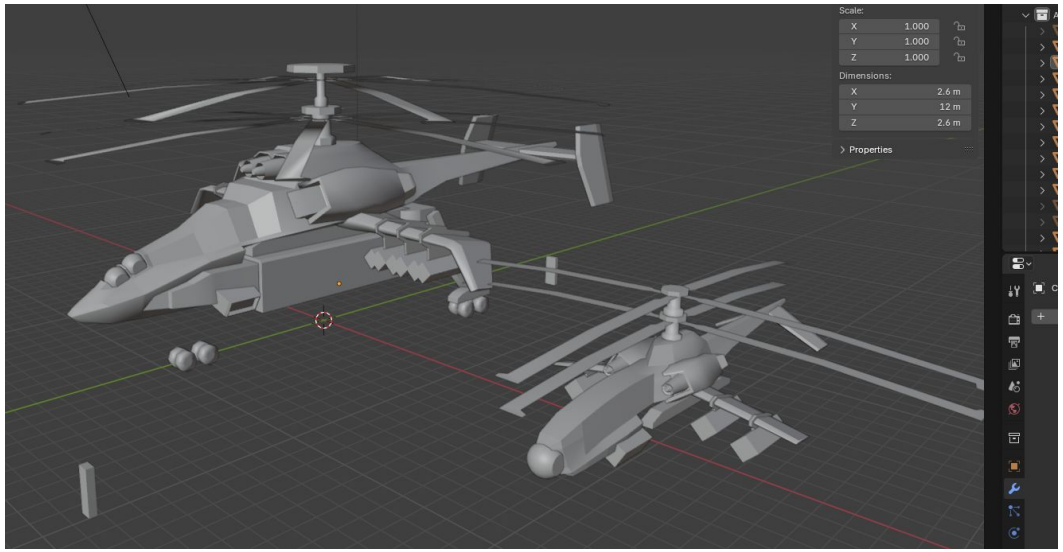

THIS is a car.

What makes a game?

This is NOT a game.



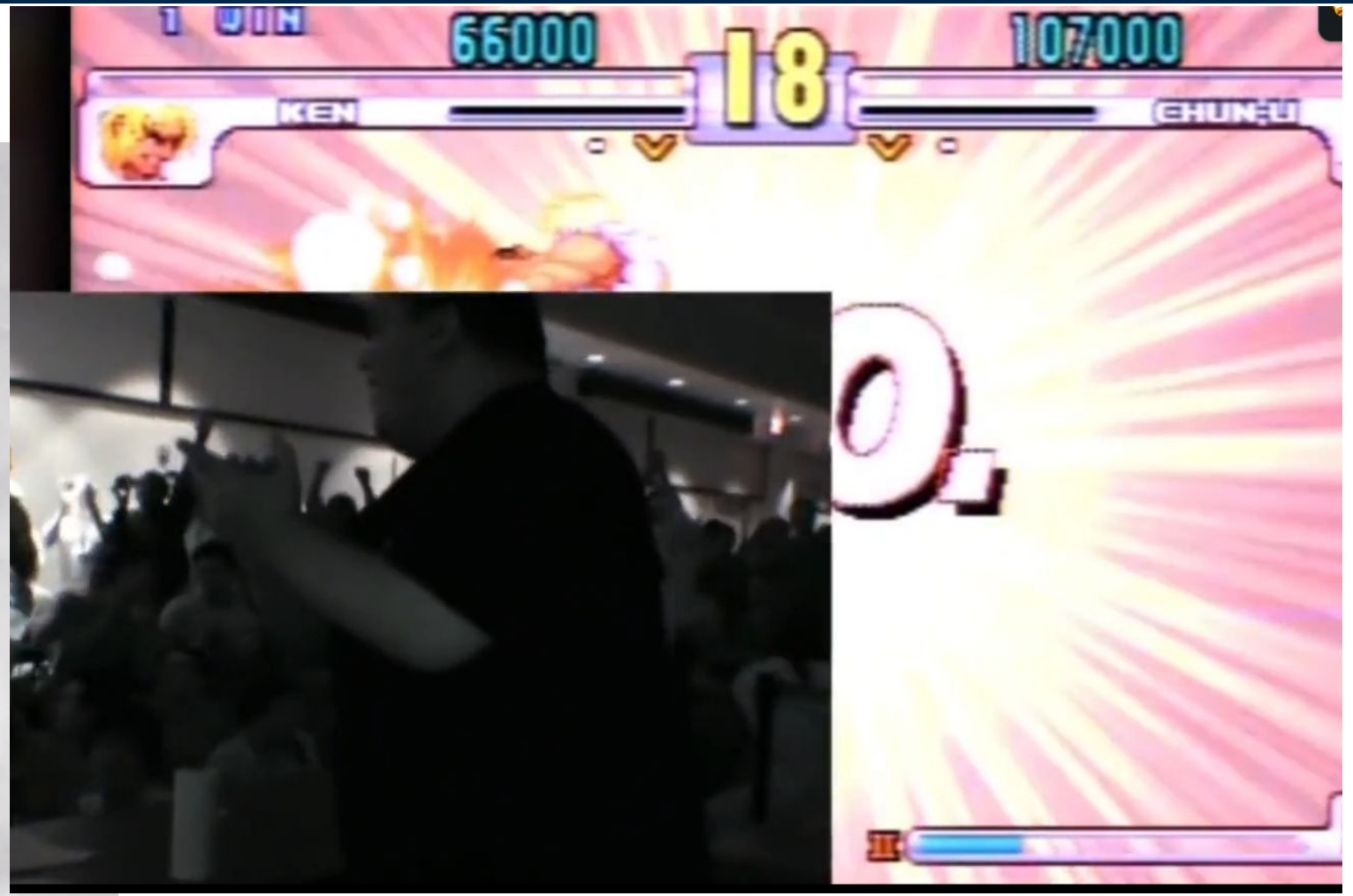




What makes a game?

THIS is a game.





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A game is how it feels.

Wrap-up

Summary

- Construct your layered Game Loop!
- Consider theme. What is your game about?
- What dramatic elements will your game use to make it exciting? How will they be used?
  - Character - Can you make characters we love? This is difficult. Drawing sprites and writing background info is not enough. What matters is what you can make happen in-game.
  - Premise - What is your “Hook” or tagline?
  - Play - What does your game offer as a Toy?
  - Challenge - Present interesting problems!
  - Story - I recommend not trying this one. It can be hard to execute